Three Places Families Get Stuck When Planning Ahead for Mom's Care

What each one looks like, why it happens, and a steadier habit for each.

Families planning ahead tend to stall in the same three places. None of them is a failing. Each comes from the way this subject is put together, and each has a steadier habit.

1 Knowing there's planning to do, and not knowing what comes next

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE You've read enough to know Medicaid may matter for Mom someday. The folder of statements is on a shelf, the will is in a drawer, and now and then someone says “we should really do something.” Nobody can say what.

WHY IT HAPPENS Mom is managing, so nothing presents itself as first. And the system is hard to see whole: the federal Administration for Community Living describes long-term services and supports as involving numerous funding streams, administered by multiple federal, state and local agencies. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Begin with what you can write down, not with what to do. Put the pieces on one page: Mom's care needs, what she'd prefer, her finances in round numbers, what you've learned about Medicaid, the legal documents you know exist. Mark what you know, what you're assuming, and what nobody has looked at. “What do we do next?” turns into a list of open questions, and that list is what a professional starts from.

---

2 Hearing something different from everyone you ask

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Your neighbor says see a lawyer. Your cousin says talk to the bank. A coworker is certain about what happened with her father, who lived in another state. Each of them sounds sure.

WHY IT HAPPENS Each may be describing the one case they know. Medicaid's overall rules are based on federal requirements, but states have considerable leeway, so eligibility rules and covered services vary from state to state. [2]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Write each piece of advice down with who said it and where their experience comes from. Don't pick a winner. Where two disagree, mark it and bring both to your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney who knows your state. For how to qualify in a particular state, the Administration for Community Living points to that state's own Medicaid office as the best source. [2]

---

3 Facing legal, financial, care and application decisions all at once

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The list seems to grow each time you look at it: powers of attorney, the house, her savings, insurance, where she'd live, who would apply for what. It can feel as though all of it has to be settled together.

WHY IT HAPPENS The subjects really are tangled, and it isn't obvious which decision leans on which. The Administration for Community Living says most people are unable to handle the complexity of planning their medical and financial futures on their own. [3]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Don't try to put the decisions in order yourself. Write each one down, and beside it the kind of professional it belongs to. Anything that would move money or property, change a legal document, or buy or cancel insurance waits until that professional has looked: the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money says to get legal advice and be very careful about decisions that may affect Medicaid eligibility. Putting the steps in sequence is what the planning conversation is for. [4]

The one habit behind all three

Write it down, note who said it or where it came from, and put a kind of professional beside anything that isn't yours to settle. Leave things as they are until that person has looked.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what your family should do first, whose advice is right, or what order any legal or financial step belongs in. It names three sticking points, the same three the Medicaid Planning Roadmap sees at this step. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know the three places a family tends to stall, and a habit for each. The planning interview gives that habit somewhere to go: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The descriptions of the long-term care system, of how Medicaid rules vary from state to state and of the complexity of planning come from the Administration for Community Living. The caution about decisions that may affect Medicaid eligibility is the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's. The three sticking points are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own.

1. Administration for Community Living, Aging and Disability Resource Centers Program/No Wrong Door System
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Will I Need a Lawyer?
4. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney

---